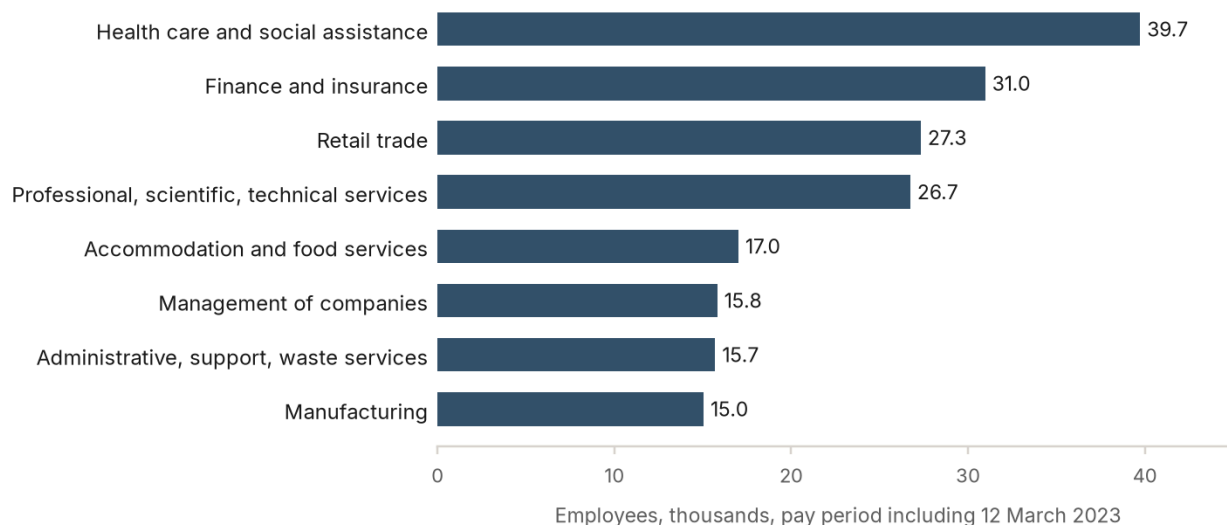


Chester County, Pennsylvania: who employs whom

A sourced brief from the Census Bureau's County Business Patterns, 2023 edition · prepared 2026-09-08 by Joshua Matalon as a sample of the format

Chester County had **15,102** business establishments with paid employees in 2023, employing **262,454** people with a combined annual payroll of **\$22.1 billion**.¹ Three sectors, health care and social assistance, finance and insurance, and retail trade, account for **37 percent** of that employment.²

EMPLOYMENT BY SECTOR



The eight largest sectors by employment. Bars are labelled with the value; the full table is on page 2.

The largest employer by headcount is health care and social assistance with 39,721 employees across 1,625 establishments.² Average annual pay per employee ranges from \$24,704 in accommodation and food services to \$166,475 in management of companies.³

HOW TO READ THE NUMBERS

Counts are establishments (locations), not firms; a company with three offices in the county is three establishments. Employment is the count for the pay period including March 12, 2023. Payroll is the calendar-year total. Since 2017 the Bureau adds statistical noise to every published count to protect confidentiality, so figures are close to but not exactly the true values; where a sector's employment is withheld entirely, the table shows the Bureau's D flag instead of a number and the derived pay figure is left blank; no sector in this county is affected.⁴ Self-employed people with no employees are not in this dataset at all.⁵

ALL SECTORS, RANKED BY EMPLOYMENT

Sector (NAICS 2017)	Establishments	Employees	Annual payroll, \$ millions	Pay per employee, \$
Health care and social assistance	1,625	39,721	2,396	60,329
Finance and insurance	994	30,962	4,214	136,089
Retail trade	1,353	27,318	1,245	45,573
Professional, scientific, technical services	2,464	26,727	3,006	112,471
Accommodation and food services	1,065	17,006	420	24,704
Management of companies	163	15,810	2,632	166,475
Administrative, support, waste services	1,150	15,694	1,011	64,415
Manufacturing	520	15,036	1,157	76,969
Wholesale trade	785	13,547	1,467	108,318
Construction	1,537	13,385	1,102	82,334
Information	329	10,617	1,607	151,368
Other services (except public administration)	1,498	10,240	393	38,424
Transportation and warehousing	272	7,719	445	57,634
Educational services	273	7,002	359	51,217
Arts, entertainment, recreation	292	6,107	177	28,966
Real estate, rental and leasing	661	3,401	260	76,414
Utilities	52	1,409	216	153,434
Agriculture, forestry, fishing	54	633	26	41,735
Mining, oil and gas	6	87	8	86,483
Unclassified	9	33	1	22,273
Total, all sectors	15,102	262,454	22,142	84,366

Payroll in the source is reported in thousands of dollars; it is shown here in millions. Pay per employee is annual payroll divided by March employment, so sectors with seasonal or part-time work read low.³

SOURCES

1. U.S. Census Bureau, County Business Patterns 2023, county file cbp23co.zip (cbp23co.txt), records with FIPSTATE=42 and FIPSCTY=029; accessed 2026-09-08. Record NAICS "-----" (all sectors): EST, EMP, AP fields.
2. Same file, records NAICS "XX----" (2-digit sectors): EMP and EST fields; share computed as the sum of the three largest EMP values divided by the all-sector EMP.
3. Same file; pay per employee computed as $AP \times 1,000 \div EMP$ for sectors with no suppression flag.
4. EMP_NF noise flag in the same file (G, H, J = noise level; D = withheld); Census Bureau, "County Business Patterns Methodology," <https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/cbp/technical-documentation/methodology.html>.
5. Census Bureau, "Nonemployer Statistics" is the separate series that covers businesses without paid employees, <https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/nonemployer-statistics.html>.
6. Sector names: NAICS 2017 two-digit sector titles, <https://www.census.gov/naics/>.